

A Guide to Launch an MVP

Playbook for Startups



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Targeted Audience of this Guide

Who is this guide for?

This guide is for startups who are on the expedition of creating a product that their customers can actually procure.

- ✦ We wrote this guide primarily for someone who may not be tech savvy, and yet would want to develop a product that could benefit any consumer.
- ✦ This guide will give an idea about how one can develop a product that can be used and enjoyed by their audience.
- ✦ It is also intended to give an insight about how a startup can develop a version of a product that they can release it in the market and move forward based on the critique that they receive from the audiences.



We have had some exciting experiences on how to create an MVP and we are happy to share some of the insights that we have learned along the way.

A Brief about MVP

What does MVP mean?

Eric Ries, who introduced the concept of the minimum viable product as part of his Lean Startup methodology, describes the purpose of an MVP this way:



“

It is the version of a new product that allows a team to collect the maximum amount of validated learning about customers with the least amount of effort.

When Less is More

A minimum viable product is a part of your product which allows you to learn how your target audience react to the functionality of the product. It helps a user to validate and adopt a product idea, early in the product development life cycle. MVP helps the product team receive user feedback as quickly as possible in order to iterate and eventually help develop a product that appeals to the user at an early stage rather getting a negative feedback from the user after fully developing the product.



A **build-measure-learn** methodology is followed in developing an MVP, where you **build** a product for a customer, you **measure** and validate the results of the build and then **learn** to respond to customer needs and improve the product.



MVP is basically a product that includes the core features without any advanced tools

- Frank Robinson, SyncDev

Advantages of building an MVP

Time/Money Saving

Developing a presentable product is overwhelmingly expensive these days, especially when you have a constrained budget.

Maintaining a stability between delivering the main features as well as being cost efficient can be achieved through building an MVP.

It also enables the delivery of a user appealing product in a fairly shorter time and is faster to implement.



Understand Audience

MVP will help you clarify the needs and demands of the target audience. It allows you to learn more about your end-user's perception about the product based on which you can plan and prioritize what you can change about the product.

Track Product Health

MVP helps you to predict further iterations of development – whether it is continuing as per the plan or are there any deviations in it. It may not be a primary task to create an MVP, but it will help you identify the weak points and help you focus on elements that has to be improved.



Create Buzz Among Stakeholders

MVP plays a crucial role in showcasing your business potential as it proves the merit of your product and secures funding for future development.

Your investors will have the trust that you actually have a team that is working on something real.

Developing an MVP has become a common practice amongst many startups as it is useful in the proper planning of a product



Less Re-work

After developing an entire product to find out that it doesn't meet your users' needs, you can avoid the chaos of having to redevelop it by creating an MVP version of the product



Importance of building an MVP

Convert your ideas into action

Now that you have an idea about what an MVP is and how useful it is to build an MVP in order to withstand the strong competition in the market, you must be worried about where and how to start?



Let us suppose that you have a business proposition in mind, an idea to develop a product that could be of benefit to any end user.

For example, you plan to develop a simple mobile application where a user can post and share their photos, videos, any random thoughts or quotes. You would have already done a research about the application that you are going to develop; is it going to be unique from the other applications that are already available in the market

who is going to be your customer persona, who are the possible competitors and how different are you going to be from others in terms of the idea and execution. You might have a blueprint of your idea that might seem jumbled and without shape. How will you execute your ideas into action?

MVP plays a crucial role to help you develop a basic version that covers the rudimentary features and release it to the end user in order to get their feedback and improvise on it, iteratively.

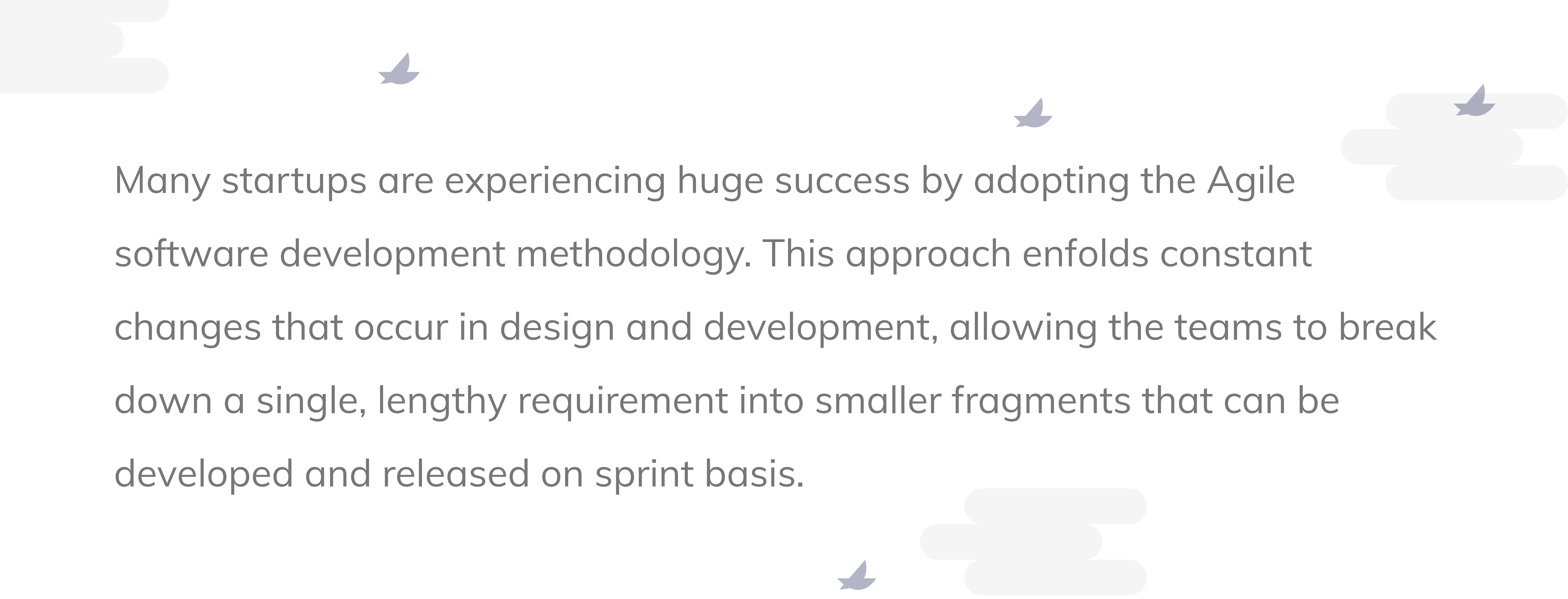
MVP assists you to arrange your jumbled ideas and shape it in an orderly manner. It will help you identify.

Solutioning Phase

How does Agile benefit here ?

Agile methodology helps promote the flow of your value through continuous improvement and feedback from your customers.





Many startups are experiencing huge success by adopting the Agile software development methodology. This approach enfolds constant changes that occur in design and development, allowing the teams to break down a single, lengthy requirement into smaller fragments that can be developed and released on sprint basis.

To be precise, you build a small working part of the entire product and give it your customer for their reviewal and feedback

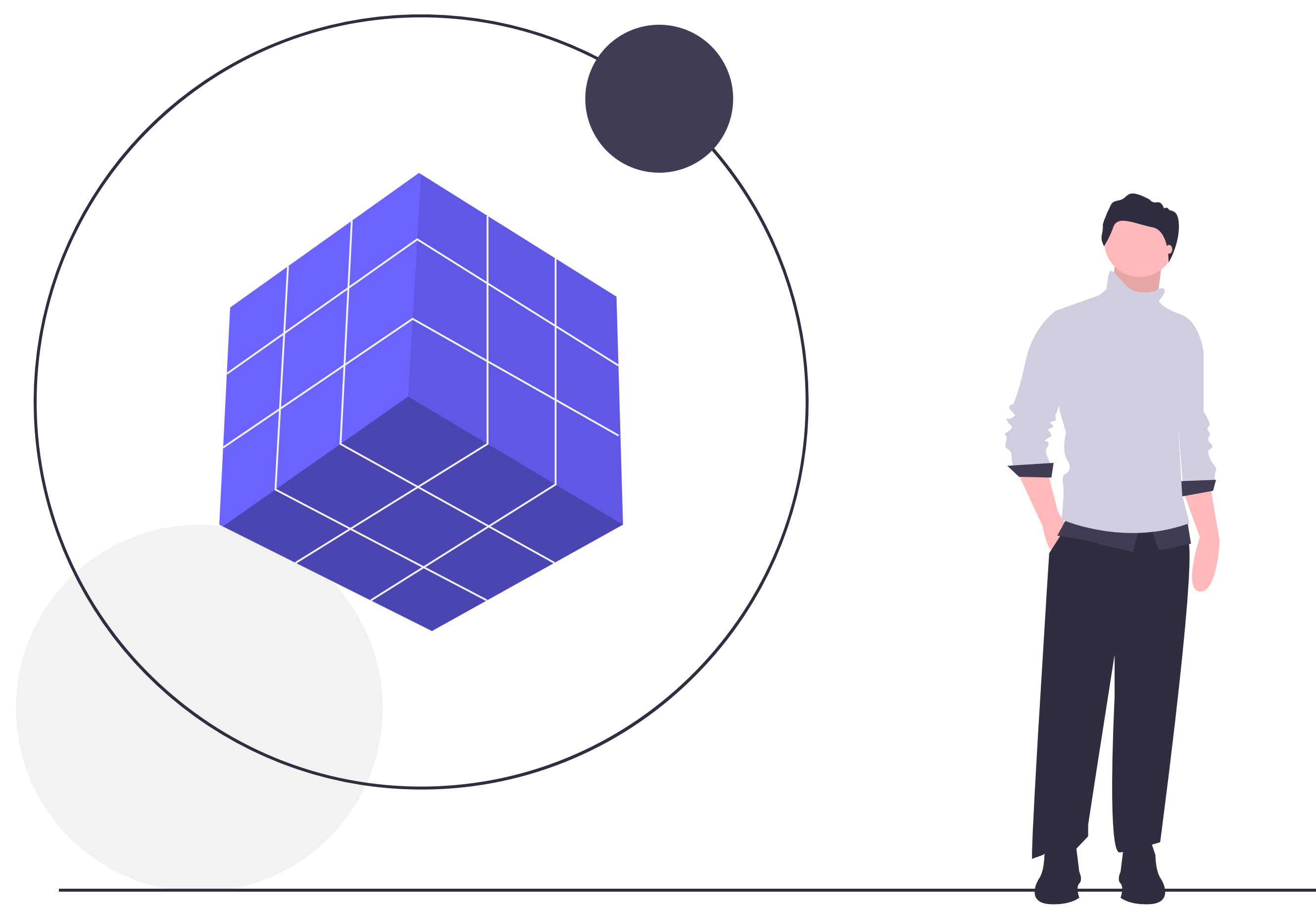
And work on the feedbacks iteratively in order to get the product built within the allotted budget and a stipulated time frame.

This will not only help you capture the end user's conception about the product, but will also help portray your ideas to investors.

How does Optisol inculcate MVP ?

Our scrum team here at Optisol carries out a set of tasks, that happens pre-development and post-requirement phase which helps our customers in the following ways:

- ✈ Get a basis on how they will need to be working with us.
- ✈ What are their roles in the solutioning phase?
- ✈ How their final product is going to be?



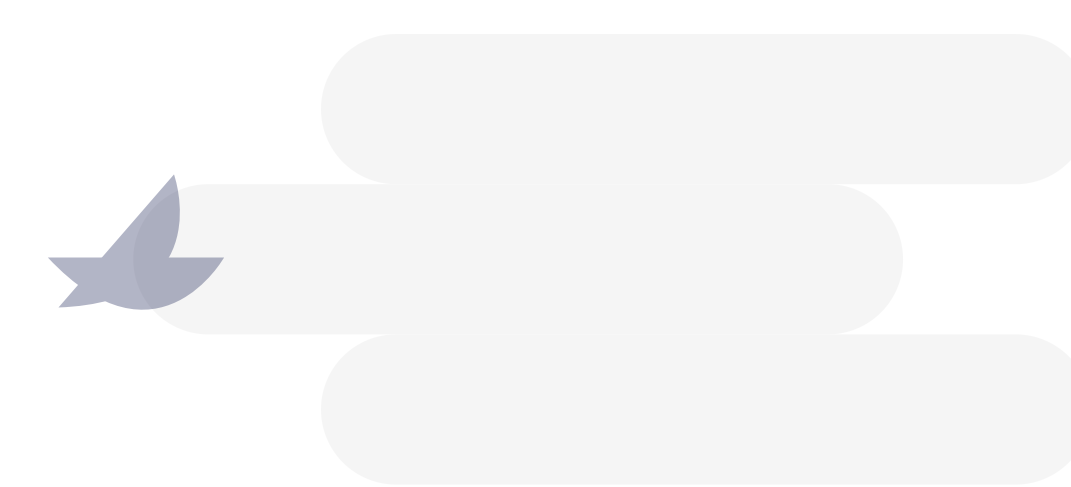
During the solutioning phase, which is otherwise known as Sprint 0 in Agile, we create a vision and a rough product backlog which will give an estimate of the product release. It is more of a preparation Sprint which is carried out before doing the actual Sprints.

We segregated the solutioning phase into three major stages which will help you comprehend the core business aspects.

First Aspect of Solutioning

The Scope definition

Defining the scope of the product is the primary aspect that helps the product team identify the features and functions of the product. It is more of detailing the problem and expanding the understanding towards the problem. Solution to the problem is attained by identifying the User Personal or Persona Analysis,



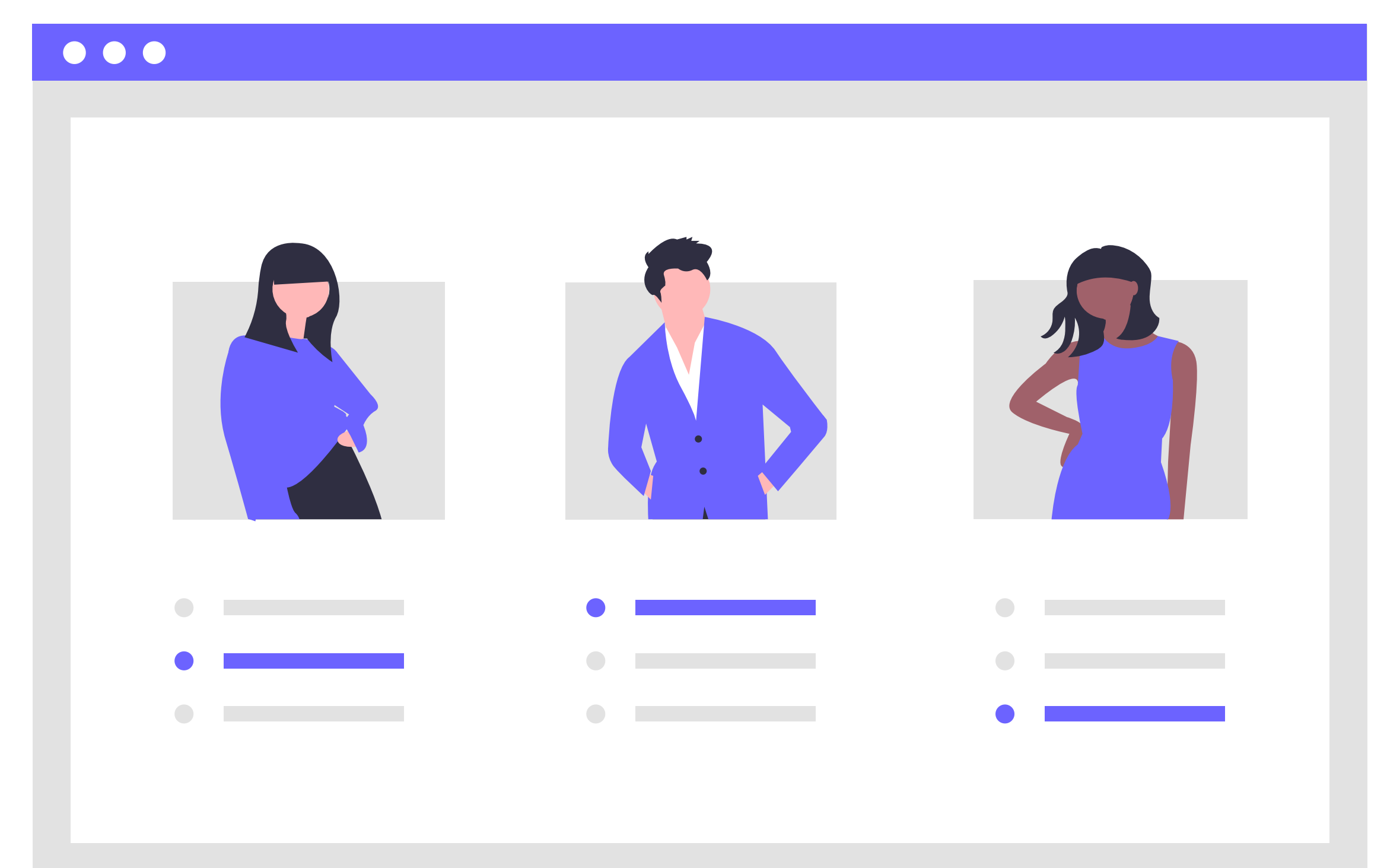
Documenting the solution in terms of Use Cases and User Stories and representing the overall flow of the process using Flow diagrams. These processes are further expanded by paying more attention to end User Interface and Experience (UI/UX) and documenting the experience in terms of Wire Frames and UI click through prototypes.

Persona Analysis

It helps you identify the end user of your application and the key elements that the user expects. Talk to a lot of users and find out what they actually need. You need to frequently update them with the strategies and get feedbacks from them.

Use case catalog

It describes the interaction between the actor i.e., the end user and the goals associated with them. A use case will define the number of actors who are involved in the application



and the tasks that will be performed by them. This will help you get an idea of the list of features that will be provided in the application and help correlate with what you have in mind about the application.

For example, let us take an instance where the user wants to login to a mobile application. Use case catalogue for a login task will look like this

Use case	Description	Complexity	Priority	Remarks
Login to the Application	This use case enables the MC to login to the application by entering a name and mobile number and verifying the mobile number.	Medium	High	If user logs in for first time or logs out after using the application, login page must appear.

Use case and Description

It represent the task or a feature and a brief description about it.

Complexity

It denotes how complicated this feature is for a developer to develop it.

Priority

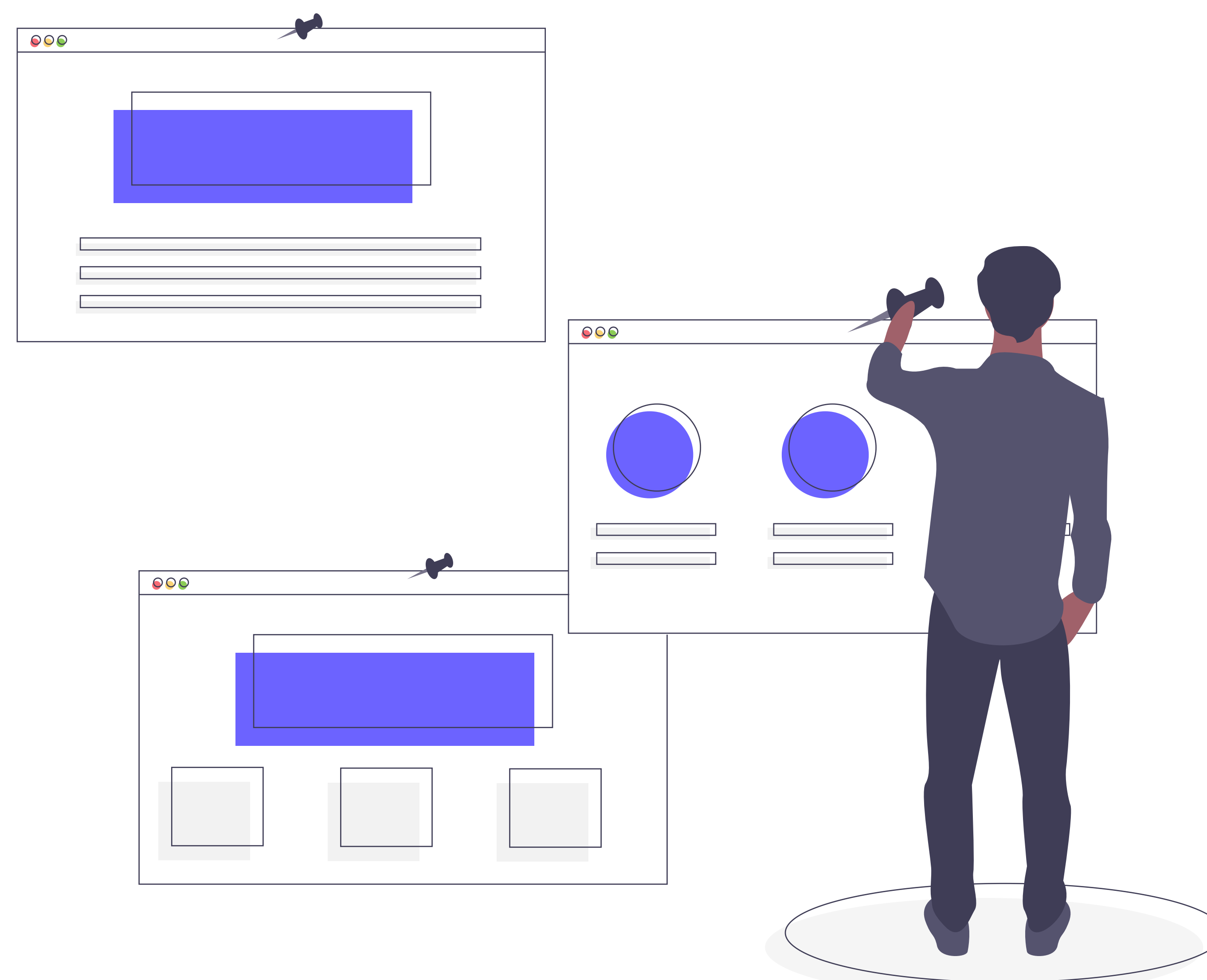
It represents the importance of this feature in the application.

Remarks

It refer to any additional information that needs to be given for this feature.

User Stories

They are a detailed version of the Use cases with an explanation of what the end user as an actor of a system or an application needs to do in order for an action to be completed or a goal to be achieved. A user story is usually written in the below format.



**As a <type of user>, I want <some goal or objective > So that
<benefit, value>**

User stories are one of the primary development artifacts for Scrum and Extreme Programming (XP) project teams. A user story is a very high-level definition of a requirement, containing just enough information so that the developers can produce a reasonable estimate of the effort to implement it. This article covers the following topics. User stories are one of the primary development artifacts for Scrum and Extreme Programming (XP) project



User story for logging in to an application looks like below.

As a user, I want to enter my user name and password, so that I can login to the application.

Acceptance criteria 1:

- ✈ Given, the user should be able to login to the application.
When the user is already registered and enters the user name and Password.
- ✈ Then, the user must be allowed to login if he is a registered user.

Acceptance criteria 2:

- ✈ Given, the user should not be able to login to the application.
- ✈ When the user is not a registered user and enters the user name and Password
- ✈ Then, the user must not be allowed to login and must be prompted to register first

Verifications:

- ✈ Verify if the user has entered the correct username and password.
- ✈ Verify if the user has registered/created an account already.

Validations:

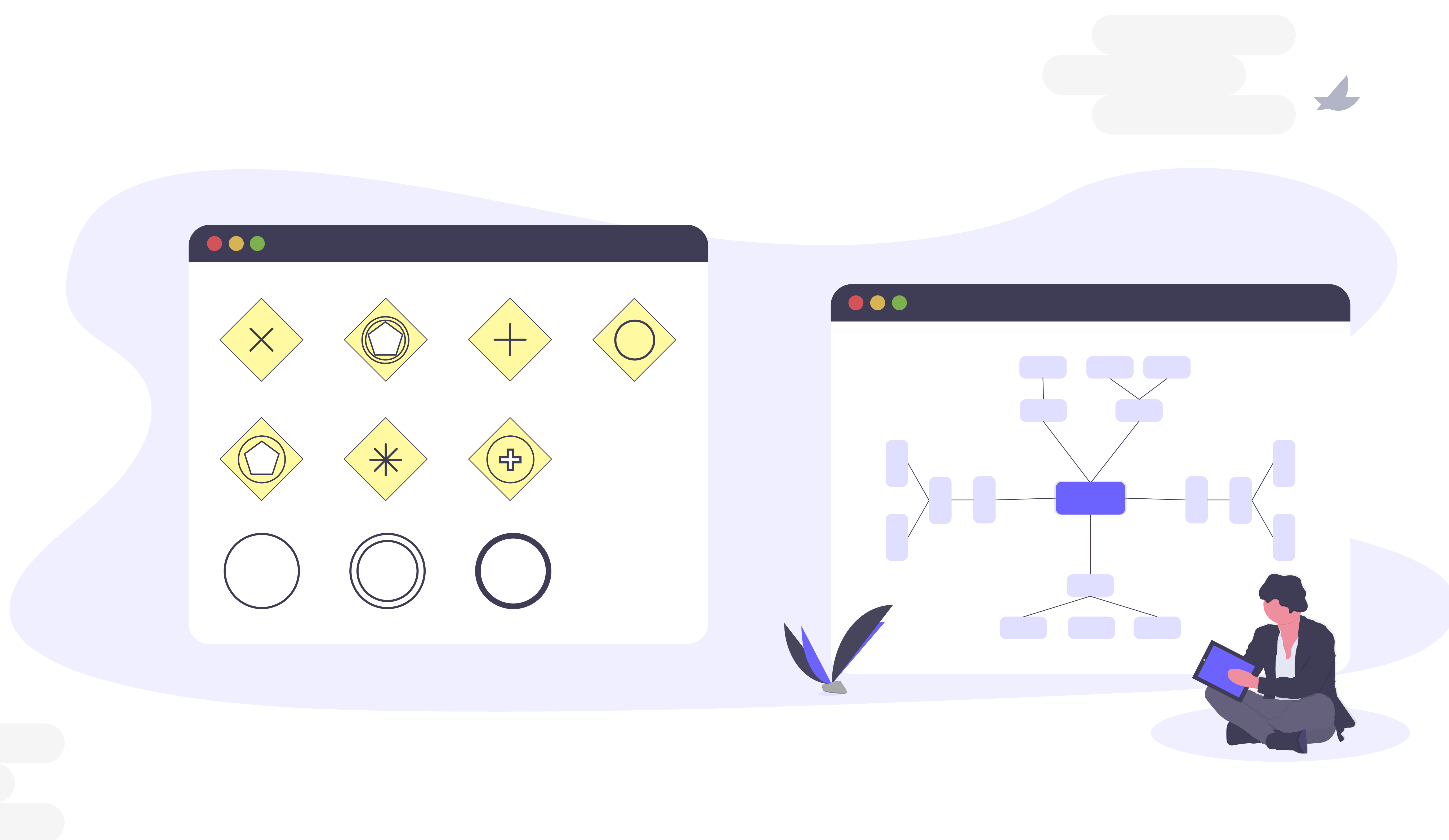
- ✈ Validate the user if a wrong user name or password is entered.
- ✈ Validate the user if the user is not registered already.

High level flow diagram

Diagrammatic representation of the sequence or the flow of workflow or process. The flowchart shows the steps in boxes of various kinds and thereby connecting the boxes with arrows.

It will give you a high level understanding or an overview of what is going to happen in case of an event.

The [Business Process Model and Notation \(BPMN\)](#) standard is commonly followed while drawing flow diagrams.



It has been designed to provide a standard notation, understandable by all business stakeholders, business analysts, technical developers and business managers. Some commonly used tools for drawing flow diagram as MS Visio, Draw.io, Lucidchart etc.

Wireframes

They are schematic representation of a page or screen. They are simple black and white layouts that outline the size and placement of certain elements in a page.

It is more like a blueprint that is used to layout contents on a page and establish the basic structure of it.



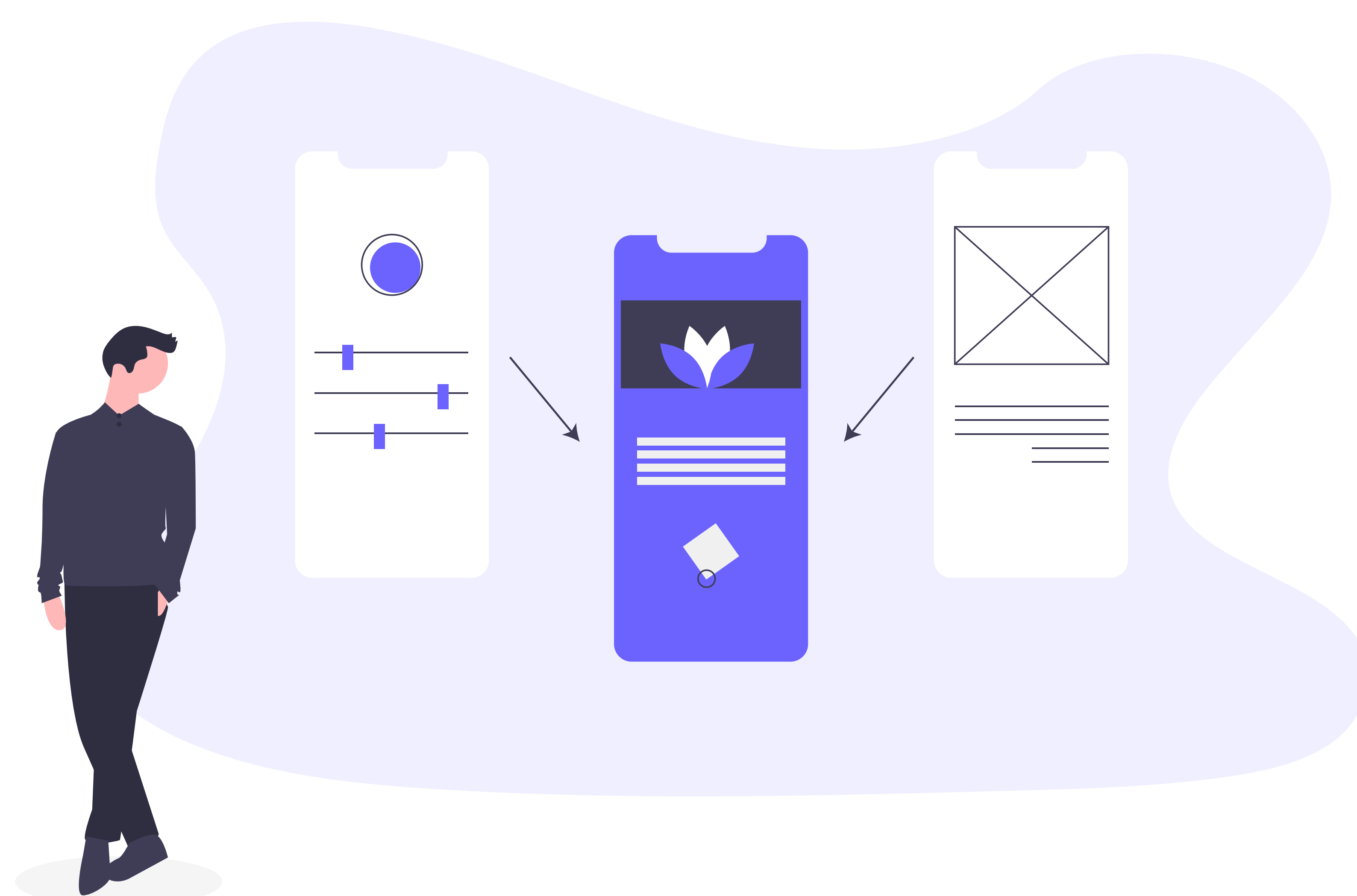
The aim of a wireframe is to provide visual understanding of a page in order to get all the stakeholder's approval before getting into the creative phase.

It is also used to ensure that the terminologies or the verbiages used in the application meet your expectations

UI Design and Prototype

It is an iterative development technique in which the technical team is involved in creating a mock-up of the User Interface for a system that works as a simulation of the final product.

The main purpose of creating a prototype is to test whether or not the flow of the product is smooth, consistent and agreed upon by you.

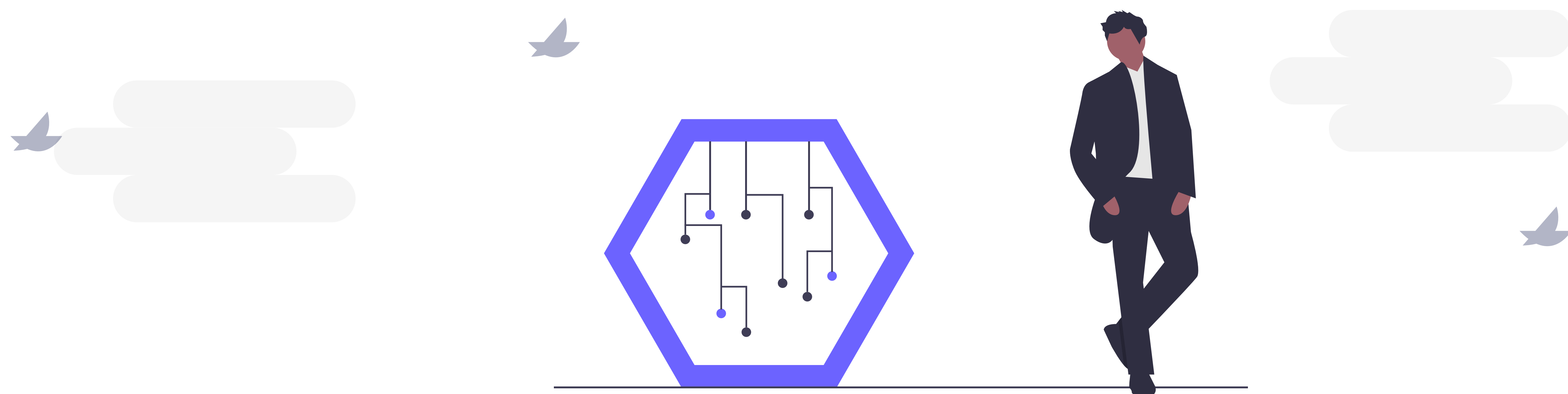


The prototypes are developed by designers which allows them to show their design in an interactive method, resulting in a better understanding of the product for everyone. It allows you to clickthrough a sample of the product on the device in which the application is intended to be built upon. Some commonly used prototyping tools are Adobe XD, InVision, proto.io, etc.

Second Aspect of Solutioning

Technology Stack

Once you have identified the problems and have acquired a solution to it through scope definition, you need to determine the Technology Stack.

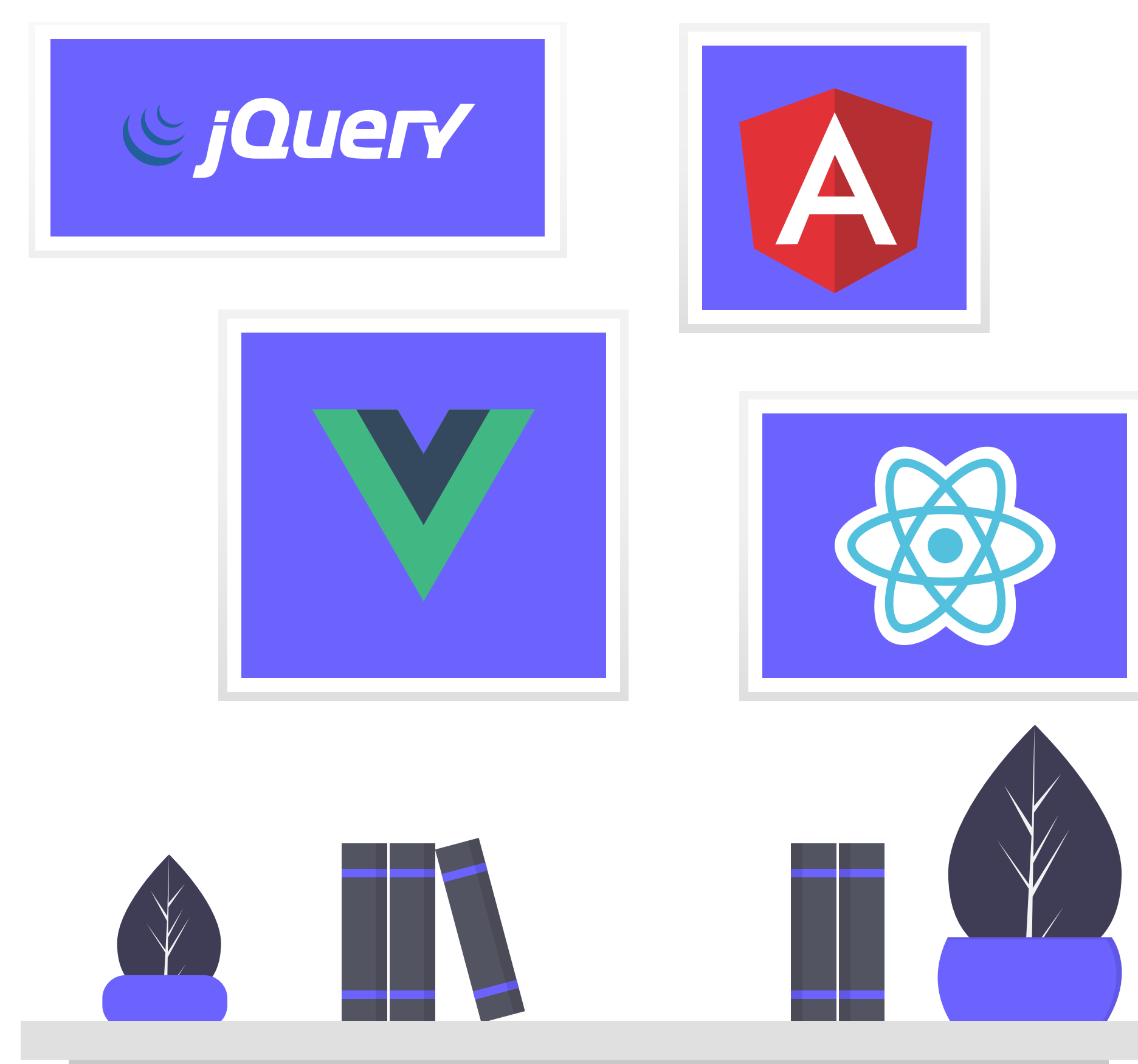


By this time, your scope will have been defined and you need to focus on determining the Technology in which the application is going to work or rather the platform in which the application is going to be developed.

Deciding the right stack

You will identify whether it is going to be a mobile application or a web application and if it is mobile, is it going to be in Android or iOS. But you will not have any idea about what technologies will be used, how and where your confidential data will be stored and where will your application be hosted. We will help you decide on the right stack for mobile, whether it is going to be in Native, React native or Cross platform and in case of a mobile application, is it going to be in NodeJS or AngularJS, JAVA or .NET.

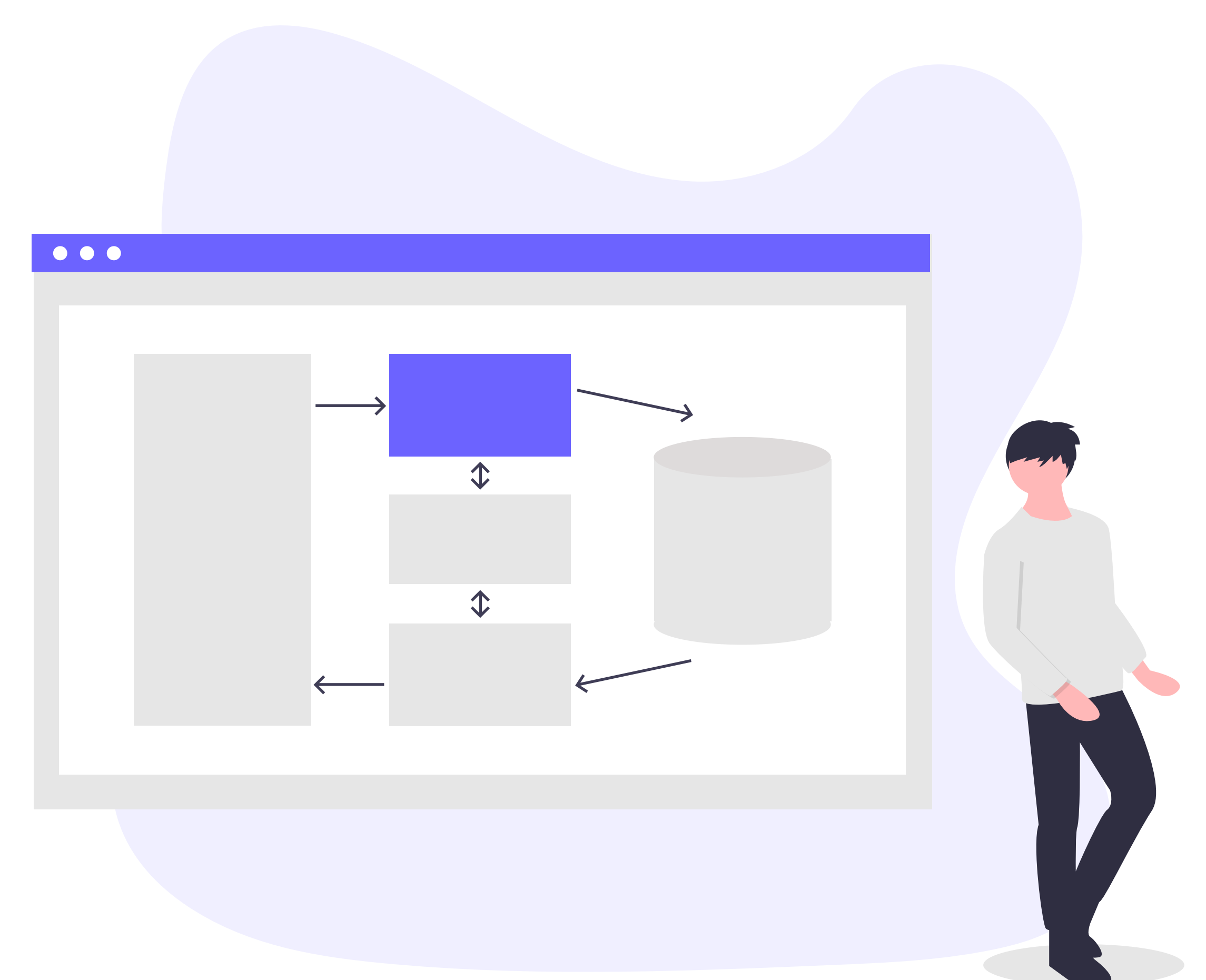
This in turn will help you recognize the technology that is scalable, maintainable and helps boost the performance of your application. The team will also determine the right cloud server for storing the data. Some of the commonly used cloud services are AWS, Azure and Google Cloud. The technical team will come up with a technical architecture to help the customers understand to an extent about the technologies that will be used.



For a more elaborate information on the technologies used, visit our website [blog1](#).

Technical Architecture diagram

It provides a complete architectural overview of the system. It contains information related to the architectural design of the software, structure of the database and the physical servers hosting the site. It helps system designers and application developers to have a high level idea of the overall structure of their system or application.



Final Aspect of Solutioning

Product Scope Management

At this juncture, the technical team will define the product backlog that has the list of all features that have been defined in the Use Case. The timeline for completion of these features will also be defined, where the features will be segregated sprint-wise along with the milestone value for each sprints. This will help you plan your budget accordingly where you will have to allot a certain amount of money for each sprint. This will also help you track if the development is going as per schedule or are there any delays.



Sprint plan is an event that is performed in the scrum environment, where the technical team will determine the product backlogs that they will work on during a particular sprint. A sprint usually comprises of two weeks. A sprint plan is worked out based on the number of use cases that have been defined by a business analyst who will act as a product owner in the organization, on your behalf. It includes the start and end date for each

use case. After a go-ahead status from the quality assurance team, a working version of the software will be released to you at the end of each sprint where you can test the application and give your feedback.

[Milestone schedule plan](#) will include monetary value to each sprints. This value will be calculated based on the number of hours that a developer spends per week working on the features of that particular sprint.



The formats that we have defined for each activities happening throughout, are specific to our process and are subject to change depending upon the organizations. Once all the processes have been defined, it will be reviewed by our customer. This helps them get an overview of the business idea and find out what they actually desire before giving them the finished product. In short, to determine if all are on the same page in terms of understanding the product.

About Us

Our Moto



Every consumer is different and so is their thought process. We at Optisol have been following this approach with all the startups that we have worked with so far, and each one has their own success story. This guide is intended to make you stay focused on your goals, stay true to it and most importantly, give your best.

Who We Are ?



We are an IT services firm offering Digital solutions for Startups and Enterprises. We are experts in custom web and mobile application design & development, Artificial Intelligence and product implementation.

What We Do?



We are providing Optimized business solution with focus on digital transformation. We ensure that we follow protocol, be it in requirement gathering, creating prototypes, developing or testing. We have an on demand team of experts with diverse background, who collaborate via tools to build a Minimum Viable Product(MVP).

